

Game Summary

https://www.gamereactor.eu/media/70/newconeptart_1537073b.jpg

NieR: Automata is a post-apocalyptic action RPG about existential and philosophical issues presented through a proxy war. Set in a desolate Earth in which the last human survivors have retreated to the moon, androids fight to keep control of the surface from alien machines. The game itself manages to meld slick hack and slash gameplay with a meta-narrative in which your conception of being "human," of having consciousness and duty, will constantly be challenged and questioned.

Overview of the Avatars

The human proxies in this setting, mostly the YoRHa androids 2B, 9S, and A2, are very tightly designed. In my initial thoughts I expected the user to approach them only as an "Avatar as Object" because the opening to the game, essentially, treats them as machines used only for warfare. This very quickly changes in the course of the game into an "Avatar as Symbiote" relationship because of how much weight the user is forced to carry, psychically embodying the androids through their shared sorrow.

Avatar Customization and Choice

Similar to most other games, physical avatar customization is limited to none and all of the player's options lie within the "Plug-in Chip" interface. The player is literally building the android's OS system in order to assign their limited memory to anything they need, from HUD components to the ability to take damage and dodge attacks. The interface directly ties back to the game's technological themes and forces the player to recognize that they are essentially building and modifying a machine, the very core of this system is that without the "OS Chip" the avatar will immediately die.

Design Choices (Identity Characteristics)

Following the prompt to move away from stereotypical design, the design choices here are more intentional. The androids' bodies appear unnaturally pale, robotic, and doll-like in nature; their hair is black, or gray, and their gear is black and gun-metal gray and extremely gothic military styled. More specifically, their "visors"

block their eyes, literally blinding them to the truth of their nature, and their bodies move fluidly yet mechanically. Removing the sex, race, and face details on the avatar specifically forces the user to interact with the androids not as an extension of their own identity, but as sentient beings with the same concerns and emotions, despite not having human bodies.

Predicting User Influence

By forcing the user to take on duty-bound androids, I expect the user to develop a melancholy Proteus Effect and to adopt a far more passive and emotionally resonant playstyle, driven by the androids' stoic facade. In addition to that, the game utilizes Transformed Social Interaction within the ending in which the user is asked to sacrifice their avatar for another player, literally giving up their save data for a stranger. Playing the avatar makes the player feel not like a badass cyborg, but that they are carrying some semblance of suffering.